

Chicago School

The term 'Chicago School' came to describe the succession of architects, from William Le Baron Jenney on, who rebuilt the city after the great fire of 1871 and won Chicago its reputation as the birthplace of modern architecture. The Chicago School included William Holabird (1854–1923), Martin Roche (1853–1927), Daniel Hudson Burnham (1846–1912), John Wellborn Root (1850–91) and Adler and Sullivan, who were among the first to apply new technologies, particularly steel-frame construction in commercial buildings (the term 'commercial style' was widely used at the time).

The Chicago School was not a conscious or coherent group; there were no established principles to which they all adhered, nor did any of them produce a sole defining style of building. But all their buildings were individual and unique, utilizing numerous inventive construction techniques and materials. These pioneers are collectively known as the First Chicago School, with a Second Chicago School following the Second World War.



Marquette Building in Detroit, Holabird & Roche, 1905